DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

How Much Light Shines in a Dark World?

Daat Tevunot §150-152

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §150-152
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These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

From the five phases to part 4

The Rabbi recapped the five phases of mishpat. He preferred "phases" to "stages", since they are not chronological: the first 2,000 years, the present, the Temple era, Har Sinai, and the growing understanding after Mashiah. He also went back over the human parallel: conception, birth, growing up to 13, from 13 to 20, and maturity. Part 4 now asks what causes these different levels and how they connect with our role in the world.

Every attribute has content and extent

The Sekhel says (§150) that every attribute of Hashem has two aspects: its content, and the extent to which it is used.

Take mishpat. Its content includes judgment of pure kindness, judgment of pure retribution, and mercy, which is a mixture of the two. How far it is revealed changes from time to time.

The Ramhal's analogy is the human body. We are all built the same way with the same skeleton, but our strength differs. One person can do what another cannot, and even the same person feels stronger on some days than on others. So too Hashem always runs the world with mishpat. What changes is how much of it is revealed. The Ramhal says this will also explain the difference between holy days and ordinary days.

Learning from creatures

The Neshamah asks (§151) whether what has been said is not enough, and the Sekhel says (§152) that there is much more. To understand how mishpat works, we must look at the creatures Hashem made and the differences between them, because their very nature comes from His mishpat.

A participant connected this with Adam naming the animals according to their essence. The Rabbi agreed. With the hidden light he had, Adam could see their differences. The lion, the ox and the eagle are among the noble creatures on the divine chariot.

A lowly world, by design

The Ramhal puts two facts together. First, this world is dark, and what is created in it is mostly coarse. Second, everything exists only through Hashem's constant will. "If Hashem for any moment did not want the world to exist, it would cease to exist." So this lowly world must be exactly what Hashem wants. He could have removed the darkness and made everything holy, but He did not.

Why? Because He wanted reward and punishment, and that requires free choice: "you choose your lot, you create your own destiny." Without bad in the world there is no choice, and without choice there is no reward. So man had to be made from an ingredient, and under a mode of rule, in which good and bad can exist side by side. Hashem could have run the world with pure kindness. Everyone would then have "lived happily ever after", but with no free choice and no ability to shape our own identity.

The beam of light

So the state of man, higher or lower, depends on how much Hashem's light shines, and that varies. Some times are more elevated, like Shabbat and Yom Kippur, and some are less. The Rabbi brought back the picture of a beam of light that is sometimes dim and sometimes strong. Even when it is strong you must step into it: "if you don't accept Shabbat, you're going to be stuck out of the beam."

Even so, the world is never completely dark. Our animal nature rules much of the time (even the urge to eat and drink is the animal soul talking), but alongside it we have intellect and wisdom, and above all the Torah, which have nothing to do with material things. This is the combination of body and soul learned earlier: the body comes from the concealment, and the intellect from the illumination.

The Ramhal says the Hakhamim call matter homer, related to hamor, the donkey, the coarsest animal. The Rabbi mentioned the expression that tefillin worn without any thought are like "a donkey's saddle".

We control the dial

Since Hashem wants to run the world through mishpat, He has, as it were, bound Himself to it. The Rabbi put it in Hashem's words: "You are controlling Me. I have created a system in which you can control Me." Good deeds push upwards and awaken good hashgahah. Bad deeds dim the light. The exception is when Hashem chooses to lead only with love, through His sovereignty, which is bound by no law. Then there is pure, constant illumination.

Three kinds of energy

To sum up, the Ramhal describes three kinds of divine energy:

1. **A low energy** that creates the physical world.
2. **Pure, complete energy,** in which everything runs only with holiness.
3. **A combination,** in which light enters the darkness without erasing it.

The third does not refine the physical away entirely, because then it would become the second, pure spirituality, and there would be no choice. That will be the end of days. On Shabbat we are on the third level with much more light in it, not pure light, so we still have the choice to accept it or not. The Ramhal will use this to explain the different times of the calendar in the next class.

Summary

- Every attribute has content and extent. Mishpat is always present, but how much of it is revealed changes.
- The lowly state of this world is Hashem's will, so that there can be free choice and real reward.
- The world is never fully dark: alongside our animal nature we have intellect and Torah.
- Under mishpat, our deeds turn the "dial" of how much light comes down, unless Hashem overrides it out of love.
- There are three energies: physical, pure holiness, and a combination of light within darkness. The combination is where we live, Shabbat included.

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